

Lesson Plan: "In Search of Kin: Visual Anthropology & Ethnography in the Highlands"
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Total	Duration:	3	Hours
Mode:			In-person

Materials Needed:

- Projector & speakers
- Printed handouts (excerpts from ethnographic text)
- Whiteboard/Markers
- Sticky notes
- A4 sheets for individual writing
- Notebook/journals for students

Session Objectives

By the end of the session, students will:

1. Understand human-animal kinship through an ethnographic lens.
2. Explore belief systems and ritual ecology in Himalayan highlands.
3. Identify core principles of visual anthropology in observational filmmaking.
4. Reflect critically on ethics, representation, and subjectivity in filming.
5. Engage with both textual and visual data to derive anthropological insight.

Detailed Work Plan**Warm-Up & Context Setting****Step-by-step:**

1. Welcome the students and write the session title on the board:
"In Search of Kin: Yaks, Spirits, and Stories in the Haa Highlands"

2. Ask: “*Have you ever known or heard of someone who speaks to animals as kin?*”
(Encourage short sharing, even a sentence per student.)
3. Briefly introduce the location (Haa, Bhutan), the herders (Chencho & Dawa), and the central event (loss of 30 yaks).
4. Hand out printed summaries of key concepts from the text (yak kinship, tsib, rituals, crows as omens, Ap Chundu).

Key points to highlight verbally:

- Yaks are not just animals they are family, co-survivors, spiritual companions.
- The film and reading combine storytelling, ritual, and cosmology.

Mini-Lecture: Ethnography & the Human-Animal-Spirit World

Content focus:

- Introduce *ethnography* as a method of slow, attentive, and immersive observation.
- Explain Wouters’ concept of *trans-species kinship*: herders see yaks as children and parents.
- Discuss Bhutanese spiritual ecology roles of deities, rituals, landscape beings.
- Explain the role of *the tsib* as both a cultural authority and mediator of unseen forces.

Activity:

- On the board, draw a triangle:
Herders — **Yaks** — **Spirits**
 Ask: “*How are they connected emotionally, practically, spiritually?*”
 Invite students to share or write keywords on the diagram, and refer to it throughout.

Film Screening (15 mins)

Steps:

1. Before starting, ask students to watch for:

1. Signs of emotional attachment between herders and yaks
 2. Any non-human presence (landscape, omens, rituals)
 3. How silence and waiting are represented
2. Play the film: *"In Search of the Missing Yaks"*
 3. Ask students to remain silent post-screening for a full minute, no notes, just reflection.

Guided Group Discussion

Steps:

1. Divide students into 3–4 small groups (4–5 students each). Assign each group a theme:
 1. **Group A:** Kinship between herders and yaks (body language, speech, routines)
 2. **Group B:** The invisible – spirits, omens, unseen forces
 3. **Group C:** Role of rituals, belief, and deities (Ap Chundu, crow, offerings)
 4. **Group D** (optional): Role of landscape, weather, isolation
2. Each group:
 1. Discusses 3 key moments in the film/text related to their theme
 2. Writes short bullet points on sticky notes or flipchart
3. Regroup and share their points with the class. As facilitator, cluster their ideas under broader categories on the board.

Break (10 mins)

Encourage students to step out, stretch, and reflect.

Lecture: Introduction to Visual Anthropology

Steps:

1. Define **Visual Anthropology** – the use of visual media (especially film) to study and represent cultures.
2. Discuss key concepts:
 1. *Embodied seeing* – observing with your whole presence
 2. *Framing* – what is chosen to be seen and shown
 3. *Ethics of representation* – who tells the story? How do you film the invisible?
 4. *Observational mode* – patience, minimal interference
3. Play a short 1-minute silent scene from the film again and ask:
“How did the camera position and sound influence what you felt?”

Creative Ethnography Exercise

Steps:

1. Hand out A4 sheets. Ask students to write a 150–200 word **ethnographic description** from one of these perspectives:
 1. A yak searching for its herder
 2. The mountain listening to their prayers
2. Invite 2–3 volunteers to read aloud. Offer gentle feedback on tone, depth, and reflexivity.

Ethics & Visual Storytelling Discussion

Steps:

1. Initiate open class discussion with questions:
 1. Is it okay to film sacred rituals?
 2. Can you film something that cannot be seen?
 3. What would you change if you filmed this story?
 4. Can absence be a subject of a film?

2. Conclude with reflections on the ethics of gaze, power, and empathy in visual storytelling.

Wrap-Up

Steps:

- Ask students to write one insight or question on a sticky note and post it on a board titled “Still Searching”.
- Summarize key themes:
 1. Kinship across species
 2. Spiritual landscape
 3. The power of patient observation
 4. Visual anthropology as a form of listening

Reference

Phanchung, Gyeltshen, N., Wangdi, T., & Yangzom, K. (2022). Resilience of traditional ritual practices in Bhutanese mountain farming systems amid climate change and anthropogenic activities. *Mountain Research and Development*, 42(4), V11–V18. <https://doi.org/10.1659/MRD-JOURNAL-D-22-00005>

Wouters, J. J. P. (2021). Relatedness, trans-species knots and yak personhood in the Bhutan highlands. In D. Smyer Yü & E. de Maaker (Eds.), *Environmental humanities in the new Himalayas: Symbiotic indigeneity, commoning, sustainability* (pp. 27–42). Routledge.

